

Speech Errors as a Rich Window onto the Mind

In the midst of the most fluent native speech, intelligent, articulate speakers often come out with words or phrases that, if framed in print, would look very odd, and occasionally they utter sequences of words or pseudo-words that, if they were slowed down and highlighted, would make even a schoolchild snicker — and yet, since it all happens in real time and goes whizzing by far too fast for most listeners to pay attention to both its form and its content, seldom does anyone (speaker or listeners) hear anything in the least strange. But if one is deeply fascinated by language and thought, one's ear is likely to be more open and more sensitive, and sooner or later one may begin noticing small oddities that for most people are merely parts of the bland background.

Thus it was for us, especially this book's senior author, who for more than forty years has been passionately and meticulously collecting speech errors, and whose collection merged, some twenty-five years ago, with that of his friend David Moser. This book's junior author joined the team more recently, and his careful observations add yet another dimension. The combined collection includes many thousands of errors of countless types, and a lengthy book could easily be devoted to it alone. In what follows, we shall have to settle for dipping into just a very small subset of it.

Theorizing about speech errors has come a long way since Sigmund Freud, but Freud's ideas are still deeply entrenched in the popular mind. The Freudian view of speech errors is that they are *a window onto the subconscious*, revealing dark secrets hidden in the psyche of the person who blurts them out. For this reason, errors that manage to slip out despite the conscious mind's attempt to censor them constitute a deeper, truer message than the overt, intended message. In short, a speaker's innermost soul is inadvertently revealed by their "Freudian slips". Today, this idea is still widespread but is not taken as seriously as it once was, and yet, if one interprets the phrase "a window onto the subconscious" in a less emotionally charged manner, it is still perfectly valid. Indeed, speech errors constitute audible traces (or visible ones, in the case of written errors) of mental processes far below the conscious level. Like animal tracks in a forest, they can be "read" by a careful observer and much can be gleaned from them.

After Freud, the field of error research came into its own in the early 1970s, with the work of the linguist Victoria Fromkin, who assembled a large corpus of errors and analyzed them as manifestations of unconscious processes. Significant extensions to Fromkin's work were made by, among others, the psychologists Gary Dell, Donald Norman, and David Rumelhart, who developed influential computational models of error-making. The French psychologists Mario Rossi and Évelyne Peter-Defare, as well as Pierre Arnaud, have worked in the area as well.

The goal of our discussion of error-making is to show not just the diversity of errors we all make, but also, more importantly, how our errors reveal certain facets of the ceaselessly churning mental activity of categorization through analogy-making. The first few sections of our discussion will deal with what we'll call *lexical blending*, an unconscious process that seamlessly but incoherently mixes together two or more stock lexical items, ranging all the way from long idiomatic phrases to monosyllabic words.

Rivals Mesh to Make a Mishmosh

I *watched at* him for a long time / Is that *Buckminster Palace* over there? / She grew up in a *working-collar town* / His research, now mostly forgotten, was an important *stepping block* along the way / I always carry my notes with me as a *safety blanket* / I'm *thick in the middle* of a major project / It was just a *last-of-the-minute* impulse / She always does things *on the last minute* / It seems she's *having second doubts* about it now / America has let its railroads *fall to pot* / He's had a rough time this season, *right out of the get-go* / Please *keep that into account* / She seems very much *up your wavelength* / Everyone is just *itching at the chance* to see him / I should *count my lucky stars* / His campaign speech was such a *pack of cards* / She went completely *off the rocker* / Well, I can't say that he's *shaking the world on fire* / I have to *share my shoulder of the blame* / When I saw how many people had come, it just *blew me over* / Our old car finally *bit the bucket* / Let's not *mince hairs*, please! / Okay, I'll *give a stab* at answering your question / That's the real *meat and butter* of their business / I slept till noon and *woke up like a baby* / I don't want to *be in any touch* with that guy any more / He's as *loony as a tune* / I *didn't know diddly-word* about their plans / My son *complains like a broken chimney* / I was unaware of what went on *under the scenes* / Little elves darted *hither and skither* / I might be able to *lay my fingers on it* / As a teen-ager, I was hugely *insecure of myself* / I made a great speech error *yesterday night!* / Doug is *crazed with salsa* / She was hoping to *follow in his shoes* / I *try like the plague* to avoid people like him / We're hoping to *piece apart* the details of the process / In the meanwhile, we'll *keep our eyes out for it* / But *for the meantime*, that'll be enough / His nutty ideas *aren't worth the time of day* / They'll probably *snub their nose* at you / The French *turn down their noses* at rosé wine / I wouldn't *fall for that trap!* / I woke her up when *she was just getting asleep* / Hey, you did a really *nice piece of job* there! / In their eagerness to slander him, they *stooped at nothing* / That'll surely lead you down a *tricky slope* / *What's up, Dolly?* / *Whoa, Betsy!* / Well, *for heavenly days!* / *Goodness grief!* / Wow, that's *pretty something!* / It's going to be smooth sailing *from now on out!* / Give me a call *when you have a time* / And then I *piped in*, "Go for it!" / *Oh, I kay* — you're probably right / His three teen-age daughters really *run him nuts* / I didn't realize I was *treading on anyone's sacred cows* / I *bought the bullet* on that one / It's not gonna *make a big deal*, right? / I hope you can *steer your way clear* to making it to my party / My parents are *breathing down my back* / It's *no skin off my teeth* / By then, the campaign was *in high swing* / You actually need *magnifying glasses* to read it / Some of my colleagues *from even further afield* will be coming / They're always *touting Princeton's horn* / When she tried to say it in Italian, she *stumbled all over her face* / I have no problem with *taking second seat* / I was thinking how *difficult on her* this must be / The magnitude of the challenge *caught me by surprise* / They had to pull him out of there *kickin' and draggin'* / Watch what you eat, or you're going to have a *heart-a-choke* / My cell phone isn't within my *hearsight* / My mother is a bit *hard of seeing* / This new place is really *my oyster bed* / None of the profs *would hesitate twice* about consulting Wikipedia / I would *walk through water* to have my kids get accepted at that school / I tell you, that guy is *one cool potato!* / He was *en his route* to Singapore via Bangkok / I wonder what Bach would sound like to someone with a *tin-deaf ear* / When I saw his name in the paper, *two and two just clicked...*

All these blends are utterances that we heard and transcribed while listening to ourselves, our families, our friends, our colleagues, and also the radio and other media. Readers who are fluent speakers of American English will probably enjoy trying to pinpoint the contributing phrases (keeping in mind that the number often exceeds two).

Many of the above “mushy meshes” are humorous, and thanks to having been set in a frame and highlighted in italics, they may seem blatantly obvious after the fact. And yet in the absence of frames or italic highlighting, only a very careful listener will consciously notice clunkers of this sort, even when the two (or more) “notes” are played loudly. Indeed, most lexical blends are picked up on by absolutely no one — neither by the speaker nor by listeners. Strange though it may seem, fluent speakers generally “hear” only the idea that was *intended*, rather than the words that hit their eardrums.

Although lexical blending is seldom noticed, it is rampant, and with some training and some careful attention, any interested observer of language and thought can start noticing the phenomenon and writing down examples of it. Moreover, recorded speech can convince skeptics that everyday speech is in fact riddled with lexical blends that escape the ear.

Our error collection was launched decades before the Web existed, and of course we never dreamed that such a powerful and public linguistic treasurehouse would one day arise. By doing simple Web searches, we have come to realize that quite a few of the errors that we once presumed were unique events in the history of the world have been independently recommitted by dozens or even hundreds of people as they type up their Web sites. It’s quite amazing. Interested readers can do searches for various blends and find how often they appear. A few of the multifarious blends that we’ve collected are still one-of-a-kind events, but many are a dime a dozen.

Once one has gotten sensitized to noticing lexical blends, blend-collecting can become quite addictive. The great appeal of blends is the rich window that, taken collectively, they offer onto the mind. They reveal that behind the scenes, as people struggle to convert their thoughts into words under the real-time pressures of everyday communication, the analogies they make in the intense effort to simplify and compress complex situations down to their essences are in constant unconscious competition with each other. Although the frenetic competition more often than not results in clear-cut hands-down winners, at times it will happen that no one category is a clear winner, and as a result, two or more lexical items — the standard verbal labels of the competing categories — will vie with one another to get themselves uttered at the same time. In such cases, snippets of the rival items will get interwoven in the speech chain and thus will emerge strange, unpredictable hybrids like the many phrases exhibited above. We will now examine a handful of examples more carefully.

A Zigzagging Cognitive Pathway inside a Dizzy Dean’s Brain

One day while talking on the telephone, a doggedly determined dean came out with the following remark about a famous and admired researcher who was the target of an intense recruitment campaign at the dean’s university: